HOMO LUDENS LUDENS

TERCERA ENTREGA DE LA TRILOGÍA DEL JUEGO
THIRD PART OF THE GAMING TRILOGY
Homo Ludens Ludens / Playware / Gameworld

laboral
Centro de Arte y Creación Industrial

Puerto de Gijón
Autoridad Portuaria de Gijón

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Commitment

Fernando Menéndez Rexach, President, Autoridad Portuaria de Gijón

The publication of this book on the exhibitions organised around the concepts of play and its echoes and interrelations in present day society is an initiative of LABoral Centro de Arte y Creación Industrial.

This book takes us on an eminently visual journey through the interactive contributions by the various artists and experts addressing the emerging role occupied by play in the developed post-industrial world, both Western and Eastern.

During its first year of existence, the galleries in the Art Centre hosted three international exhibitions focused on the idea of playfulness, in which the Autoridad Portuaria de Gijón (Gijon Port Authority) was determined to be actively engaged.

The proposal got off to a start with *Gameworld*, a new exhibition project expressly created for LABoral. The show proportioned a refreshing, retrospective and interactive view of the contributions of videogames to contemporary aesthetics in their short albeit influential existence.

Later came *Playware*, in which visitors were able to further explore this field. This time the use of the word "extension" – so widespread in entertainment or business computer applications – was truly appropriate for the second instalment, conceived to engage with the often parallel world of playfulness.

Finally, against this interesting backdrop where real life meets virtual play, Autoridad Portuaria de Gijón has had the honour to renew its support for this interdisciplinary venture by sponsoring the exhibition *Homo Ludens Ludens*.

In the particular case of *Homo Ludens Ludens* — an international exhibition examining play as a key element in our present age — the show took a step forward in its understanding of the role played by videogames in the everyday life of individuals and in the configuration of a type of society that is witnessing the emergence of the "Homo Ludens": the contemporary playing-man.

In its capacity as a founding trustee of Fundación La Laboral, Autoridad Portuaria de Gijón is determined to further its commitment with Gijón and with Asturias, over and beyond its specific function as an economic tool at the service of enterprises operating in the region, by collaborating in this educational, artistic and playful facet of the activities on offer at LABoral.

David McConville.
Optical Nervous System, 2004.
Captura *Still*

The Trickster and Transdisciplinarity

David McConville, media artist and Director, Noospheric Research (Elumenati), Asheville

The epistemology game

"The Universe is the game of the self, which plays hide and seek forever and ever."
Alan Watts

This essay is a game of hide and seek. The main player is Trickster, an archetype that hides out in the cacophony of the collective psyche of our species. It's also a metaphor for the element of mischievous play in action that brings about transformative insights. Though Trickster's numerous embodiments have appeared within mythologies, folklores, and literature of cultures around the world, we'll first need to review some of its key characteristics to help identify its often elusive appearance. The setting of the game, the *playground* if you will, is the past century of Western scientific research and philosophical discourse.

The goals of this game are twofold. First, we must spot some specific points at which paradigmatic assumptions have been challenged by a run-in with Trickster's paradoxical high jinks, identifying ways in which we can expand our own perceptions to identify its paradoxical behaviour more easily in the future. This requires an engaged immersion in the world around us so we can catalog detailed observations as well as impressions from the overall gestalt. Second, we must develop new rules and tools to help future players more intuitively recognize Trickster, since misconstruing its ludic antics can lead to endlessly frustrating cycles of confusion. Luckily, we're not the first ones to play this game, so we're free to appropriate strategies developed by previous players and modify them to fit our own circumstances.

Spotting Trickster (Illustration 1: xx)

What makes this game both entertaining and frustrating is the fact that words are insufficient to thoroughly describe Trickster's nature. Like play, it "resists all analysis, all logical interpretation" (Huizinga 1950: 3). This inability to comprehensively speak or write of its essence has prompted some cultures to limit the times and places in which tales of the Trickster can be told. Adding to this ineffable complexity, Trickster has appeared in many forms, manifesting as persons, animals or gods. However, as Jung (1959: 147) observed, "so-called civilized man has forgotten the trickster…remembering him only figuratively and metaphorically." So to make it easier for us civilized players, we'll be looking for Trickster's metaphorical manifestations within non-embodied phenomena, particularly in the form of disruptive processes.

One of Trickster's primary characteristics is its blurring of boundaries between imagination and reality. It mediates between realms of thought and states of being that are normally assumed to be in opposition. In its manifestation as Eshu, the West African god of indeterminacy, it serves as the master of the barrier between the divine and profane, the sign and the signified, the text and interpretation (Gates 1988: 6). Like Eshu, the Greek god Hermes is central to the communication between the divine realm and humanity. As implied in the root of the word "hermeneutics," Hermes is associated with the interpretation of both sacred texts and systems of meaning. Both the shaman and the medicine man contain aspects of Trickster, providing means to cross the threshold into new realities (Jung 1959: 136).

Trickster often enters into situations in which transformation is essential, serving as a mischievous change agent and disrupting paradigmatic expectations. In this context, Trickster often acts as an instigator, luring initiates into realms that are betwixt and between realities. While it frequently uses playful mischief and humor as a means of freeing rigid preconceptions, it serves the very important function of signifying the liminal phase of the ritual process. This phase presents the opportunity for initiates to reconsider and recombine culturally embedded notions into any and every possible pattern (Turner 1982: 28). This disruptive function is central to both the preservation and transformation of societies (Hyde 2002), and within it is contained the very "essence of creativity - producing new patterns, new ways of seeing the world" (Hansen 2001: 56).

Searching black and white (Illustration 2: xx)

Part of what makes Trickster's appearance threatening is that the paradoxical lesson it signifies often challenges the foundations of logic. A particularly illustrative example comes from an African tale in which two friends forget about Trickster. To test their vows of eternal friendship, Trickster makes a cloth cap with the right side black and the left side white. While the friends were in tilling their fields, Trickster rides by on a horse between the two men. Afterwards, when the men are discussing what they saw, they get into a huge fight over whether the horse rider was wearing a white or a black hat. Trickster shows up and stops the fight, pulling the hat out of his pocket to show the two men that the hat was simultaneously black *and* white (Hyde 1999: 238).

These two African friends intuitively share what we now know as Aristotlean logic. This "classical logic" holds that both sides of a contradictory theorem cannot be true, and was essential to the formulation of the scientific method. It was a central component of Newtonianism, the mechanistic paradigm that is most frequently associated with concept of materialist "Western science." This reductionist approach to knowledge was built on ever-increasing distinctions and categorizations, resulting in an explosion of disciplinary divisions that greatly contributed to human knowledge. At the same time, the pursuit to reduce all phenomena to their component parts had a polarizing effect on Western culture's view of the world. This intellectual bifurcation largely succeeded in psychologically separating man from nature, mind from matter, and the observing subject from the observed object within materialist society.

However, in the early 20th century, a series of scientific observations rocked the foundations of this classical logic – a good sign that our protagonist was at play. As the physical world was dissected into increasingly discrete components, new instruments of observation enabled scientists to peer into the incredible minute realms of existence. Western scientists assumed this quantum realm would have acted like everything else in the material world. Instead, physicists discovered paradoxical and mischievous behavior of quantum-level phenomena that didn't seem susceptible to the logical rules of the macrophysical world. They found that phenomena can simultaneously exist in two states as matter *and* energy, or what became known as the "wave-particle duality." To complicate matters further, they also reflexively observed their observations having an impact on the observed phenomena. This "observer effect" implied a direct correlation between both physical and mental activities in the macrophysical world and the quantum realm. And to top it off, Albert Einstein's theory of relativity demonstrated that space and time are curved, throwing a monkey wrench into Kant's Enlightenment-era assertion that Euclidean geometry proves there is an absolute, immutable "objective" reality.

When Western academia began to absorb the philosophical implications of these observations, a widespread "crisis of objectivity" ensued (Flusser 2002: 76). Decades of highly specialized, head-spinning, and eye-straining deconstructive discourses followed, comprised of cyclic attempts to make sense of the implications on the concepts of "meaning" and "self" of a seemingly paradoxical Universe. Meanwhile, the rapid expansion of the materialist worldview and consumer society, made possible by the ever-increasing specialization of reductionist technoscience, was alarmingly deteriorating numerous biological, cultural, and spiritual systems around the world.

Confronting Trickster (Illustration 3:xx)

When the two friends in West Africa realized Trickster could wear a hat that was black *and* white, they learned a lesson and stopped fighting. Similarly, some scientists and philosophers have worked to adapt new theories of knowledge that embrace the paradoxical and intertwined nature of reality. Philosopher Vilém Flusser proposes that it makes no sense to habitually attempt to determine which side of a binary opposition is correct. Instead, he proposes that we think differently about the nature of reality, placing it in the context of consciousness and action. By accepting that reality is a projection of consciousness, we transform from "subjects" to "projects." "Instead of "true and false," we have to put "probable and improbable." Instead of "real and fictitious," "concrete and abstract." And instead of "science and art," "to formulate and to project" (Flusser 2002: 90). Physicist Basarab Nicolescu goes so far as to propose that a non-Aristotelian logic be adopted to accept the non-dual truths implied by quantum physics. This "logic of the included middle" is meant to induce "an open structure of the unity of levels of Reality" (Nicolescu 2002).

Nicolescu goes on to propose that the antidote to hyper-specialization that arose from reductionist science is the adoption of a new unifying "transdisciplinary" approach to knowledge. He calls for a synthesis of the best elements of ancient and modern worldviews, pursuing knowledge between, across, and beyond disciplines and cultures. The specific elements of this integral worldview are outlined in the *Charter of Transdisciplinarity,* including such broad-ranging visions as the reconciliation of the sciences with humanities, arts, literature, poetry, and spiritual experience, an acknowledgment of the planetary and cosmic dimensions of human dignity, a development of open attitudes towards myth and religion, and revaluing the role of intuition, imagination, and the body within the transmission of knowledge. Stressing the urgency of this proposal, Nicolescu warns that "everything is in place for our self-destruction, but everything is also in place for positive change, just as there have been at other great turning points in history." Sounding like a scientific shaman, he proposes that adoption of rigorously syncretic vision can result in a "visionary, transpersonal, and planetary consciousness, which could be nourished by the miraculous growth of knowledge" (Nicolescu 2002: 8).

Switching models (Illustration 4: xx)

Though the observations of paradoxical phenomena resulted in a "crisis of objectivity" for much of Western academia, an "opportunity for projectivity" can be found in these more radically optimistic and integral approaches. Instead of becoming distraught over the mischievous quantum and cosmic behaviors, Flusser and Nicolescu suggest ways of strategically evolving the rules of the game for adapting to a new perception of reality. These reasoned responses imply that the potential for transformation is increasing, and may even possibly have begun triggering the *gestalt switch* (Kuhn 1962). Thomas Kuhn defined this as a process underlying revolutionary moments in science prior to shifting to a new paradigm, in which mutations of meaning can bring to light different but complementary images of reality.

Bringing this new image into being is central to the second goal of our game. The discovery and exposition of these new theories of logic and knowledge (consider them our cheat codes) are strong indications that we have been successful in finding Trickster. However, inherent in the establishment of this new integral framework is the implication that theoretical approaches are not enough: they must be complemented by practical tools to help future players continue to develop informed strategies. Here we can once again turn to the clues left for us by other players so these tools can be designed to effectively formulate these new images of reality.

Applying these transdisciplinary cheat codes, we can see that the biggest opportunity for developing these tools may be through the transformation of the import placed on the words on this page. This linear writing model of communication has served the specialization of language well, which in turn was the cornerstone of the explosion in disciplinary knowledge. However, this specialization made it incredibly difficult to move outside of one's own knowledge space and becoming fluent in another disciplinary language. To remedy this, David Turnbull (1999: 228) suggests incorporating a multiplicity of knowledge traditions in what he calls a "third space," requiring the use of communication tools beyond those rigidly defined and applied within a single tradition.

Flusser (2002) provides further insights into the potential of these communication tools to evolve transdisciplinary communication. He views these tools as "models" that are "manifestations of the way we find ourselves in the world." By changing our models, he believes that we can "literally change the understanding of the world" and our place in it. In the context of the current *zeitgeist*, he asserts that the linear writing model must be complemented by more experiential "intersubjective" models. His "phenomenological vision" calls for collaborations between new media artists, philosophers, and scientists to develop tools than can effectively communicate multidimensional space-time phenomena across disciplines, moving beyond the representation of phenomena as objects to the projection of them as living experiences. He cites these opportunities for using new media for reflexive contemplation as a crucial element of the ongoing paradigm shift, suggesting that it could change our vision of the world in "a way we cannot begin to imagine."

Form following function (Illustration 5: xx)

I share the belief that the development of new media environments is central to the success of the current shift in epistemological understanding. My own work is focused on developing these intersubjective models for phenomenological communication, particularly as it relates to transdisciplinary research, education, and collaboration. The particular manifestations of the collaborative and interstitial *third space* upon which I'm focused are domed projection environments, alternately known as "immersive vision theaters." These systems have evolved from numerous historic predecessors, many of which were designed to immerse audiences within large-scale, frameless multi-sensory gestalts (McConville 2007). I deploy these environments to facilitate psycho-cosmological explorations, working to integrate visualized data and concepts, narrative forms, and visuospatial immersion to create a sense of collective presence within externalized thought experiments and imaginal realms.

In the design of these environments, I have found that mimicking many aspects of the paradoxical, playful, and reflexive tendencies of Trickster has greatly increased the sense of play, liminality, and immersion for participants. By projecting spherical perspective imagery onto a domed screen that envelops the audience, the natural geometric mapping and gestalt of the human visual field is mimetically reproduced. The mediated experience is therefore effectively un-framed, blurring the perceived distinctions between "subjective" experience in the audience's mind and "objective" external screen. Through this destabilization of the rigid boundaries between the mind and screen, participants' own perceptions reflexively lure them into the liminal realm of direct experience (Pepperell & Punt 2006: 81). These immersive spaces also share an important characteristic with play, which Huizinga (1950: 19) cites as the "spatial separation from ordinary life… hedged off from the everyday surroundings." He further notes that "marking off some sacred spot is also the primary characteristic of every sacred act." Like sacred play within caves, temples, magic circles, and other ritualistic settings of the past, these environments are designed to facilitate the crossing of thresholds by immersing participants within an intersubjective conscious experience. Finally, my collective (www.elumenati.com) has developed fully inflatable domed environments and incorporated game controllers for navigation to further blur the distinctions between an "immersive visualization" and a "bouncy toy."

From the media production perspective, I am currently focused on three primary projects: 1) the creation of linear productions to experientially illustrate the lectures and philosophies of Zen philosopher Alan Watts, 2) the development of narrative and navigational structures for guiding interactive visualizations of the entire observable Universe using NASA's Digital Universe Atlas dataset, and 3) the creation of an interactive visual hallucination simulator. However, the applications for which these systems have been applied traverse the disciplinary gamut, with many of the transgressing disciplinary boundaries. For instance, the ongoing Uniview project (Emmart, 2005) has been designed to integrate data at every scale within an interactive and networkable rendering engine, essentially serving as a real-time version of Charles and Ray Eames' classic *Powers of Ten* short film. Within this environment, data from any spatial or temporal scale can be incorporate and holarchically integrated, enabling guides to telematically control the immersive experiences of globally distributed audiences. The ability to seamlessly navigate between scales illustrates the extent to which the concept of disciplinary boundaries becomes a non-sequitur within these phenomenological environments, much as they are in our everyday lived experience.

The game continues (Illustration 6: xx)

In *Homo Ludens*, Johan Huizinga (1950: 4) writes that "primitive man seeks to account for the world of phenomena by grounding it in the Divine." However, the paradoxical scientific observations of the early 20th century directly resulted in the processes through which modern man has rediscovered the Divine. Like Trickster's black and white hat, discoveries from the core of Western science challenged observers' logical and paradigmatic expectations. The resulting "crisis of objectivity" has led to the emergence of a new syncretic worldview which is based in part on the reconciliation of science with the spiritual experience. Trickster never left, and it never bores of hide and seek. It is up to us to re-cognize its powerful lessons as they are still essential to our own transformation.

Huizinga also writes that every culture has developed unique ways of inducing an "imagination" of reality to engage in archetypal activities of human society. In both my work and play, it is my intent to assist with the emergence of 21st century communication models to induce our collective imagination of a more integral and playful reality. New experiential models of mediated communication are providing opportunities to accelerate the ongoing epistemological shift, both literally and metaphorically providing crucial "big-picture" perspectives. In the words of R. Buckminster Fuller, "You can't better the world by talking to it. Philosophy to be effective must be mechanically applied."

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